MODULE 06

Hair care

Healthy hair and scalp, and how to spot hair loss early enough to do something about it.

Reading time	Budget	First visible results	Prerequisite
About 25 minutes	$10–40 / month	2 weeks (scalp) to 6 months (loss)	Module 01

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE, YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

Wash and style your hair without damaging it.

Fix dandruff with the right shampoo.

Tell normal shedding from early male pattern hair loss.

Know which hair loss treatments are proven, and why they go through a doctor.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS

CONSENSUS Backed by research and professional guidelines.

PRELIMINARY Promising results, limited studies. Might be worth it, no guarantees.

WARNING Ineffective, risky, or both. Don't do it.

MEDICAL ADVICE This belongs to a healthcare professional.

6.1 How hair works

Each hair follicle cycles through three phases: a **growth phase** that lasts several years, a short **transition phase** of a few weeks, and a **resting phase** of about three months, after which the hair falls out and a new one starts growing. At any given time, most of your hairs are growing. CONSENSUS

That's why **losing around 50 to 100 hairs a day is normal**. Seeing hair in the shower drain or on your pillow isn't, by itself, a sign of balding. CONSENSUS

6.2 The everyday routine

Washing

Your scalp / hair	How often to shampoo	Notes
Oily scalp, short hair	Daily or every other day	A gentle shampoo daily is fine. Focus on the scalp.
Normal	2 to 4 times a week	Rinse with water on other days if you train.
Dry scalp, or curly / coily hair	1 to 2 times a week	Curly and coily hair loses moisture easily. Co-wash or rinse in between.

- **Shampoo goes on the scalp**, conditioner on the lengths (not the scalp) if your hair is longer than a couple of inches.
- **Lukewarm water**, not hot. Massage with fingertips, not nails.
- **Pat dry** with a towel, don't rub hard. Wet hair is more fragile.
- **Washing often doesn't cause hair loss.** You just see the hairs that were already shedding. CONSENSUS

Styling without damage

- **Heat**: blow dry on medium heat, keep the dryer moving, use a heat protectant if you use a straightener.
- **Tight hairstyles**: tight man buns, braids or ponytails worn constantly can pull hair out over time (traction alopecia). Loosen them and change position. CONSENSUS
- **Bleach and chemical treatments** weaken hair. Get them done by a professional and space them out.
- **Scalp sunburn** is real. Wear a hat or use a scalp-friendly SPF if your hair is short or thinning.

6.3 Dandruff and itchy scalp

Flakes and an itchy scalp are usually **seborrheic dermatitis**, linked to a yeast that lives on everyone's skin. It's common, not about hygiene, and very treatable. CONSENSUS

Active (in the shampoo)	Availability	Level
Ketoconazole 1%	Over the counter (2% by prescription)	CONSENSUS
Zinc pyrithione	Over the counter	CONSENSUS

Active (in the shampoo)	Availability	Level
Selenium sulfide	Over the counter	CONSENSUS

1. Use a medicated shampoo **2 to 3 times a week**, alternating with your normal shampoo.
2. **Leave it on 3 to 5 minutes** before rinsing. That's when it works.
3. Once it's under control, keep using it once a week to prevent it coming back.

Red, thick or painful patches, or no improvement after a month? See a doctor: it could be psoriasis or another scalp condition. MEDICAL ADVICE

6.4 Male pattern hair loss

Androgenetic alopecia is the most common cause of hair loss in men. In genetically susceptible follicles, a hormone called **DHT** (dihydrotestosterone, made from testosterone) gradually shrinks the follicles, producing thinner, shorter hairs until they stop. It's very common: by age 50, about half of men have some degree of it. CONSENSUS

Early signs

- The **temples recede**, forming an M shape that keeps progressing.
- The **crown thins**: more scalp visible under bright overhead light.
- Hairs on top get **finer and shorter** than those on the sides.
- Your hairline in photos from **1–2 years ago** looks clearly different.

A maturing hairline (the hairline moving back slightly and evening out in your late teens or twenties) is normal and doesn't always mean balding. Comparing photos over time, and a doctor's assessment, tell the difference.

> **WHY EARLY MATTERS**
>
> Proven treatments are much better at **keeping** hair than at **regrowing** it. Follicles that have fully miniaturized for years are hard to bring back. If you notice signs, see a doctor sooner rather than later. MEDICAL ADVICE

Other causes of hair loss

Cause	What it looks like	What to do
Telogen effluvium	Diffuse shedding all over, 2–3 months after a trigger: illness, high fever, crash diet, major stress, surgery.	Usually recovers on its own within months once the trigger is gone. See a doctor if it lasts.
Alopecia areata	Round, smooth bald patches, sometimes in the beard.	Autoimmune. See a doctor. MEDICAL ADVICE
Nutritional deficiencies	Diffuse thinning, often with fatigue.	Blood test (iron, vitamin D, thyroid). Don't supplement blindly. MEDICAL ADVICE

Cause	What it looks like	What to do
Traction alopecia	Thinning where hair is pulled (temples, edges).	Loosen hairstyles. See a doctor if it doesn't recover.

6.5 Treatments: what's proven

Everything in this section is for information so you can have an informed conversation with a doctor. **Don't start, combine or buy these treatments on your own.** MEDICAL ADVICE

Treatment	How it works	Level	Important
Minoxidil, topical 5%	Prolongs the growth phase and enlarges follicles	CONSENSUS	FDA-approved, over the counter. Initial shedding in the first weeks is common. Effect stops if you stop.
Finasteride 1 mg	Lowers DHT levels	CONSENSUS	Prescription. FDA-approved for male pattern hair loss. Possible side effects, including sexual side effects and mood changes, must be discussed with your doctor. MEDICAL ADVICE
Oral minoxidil (low dose)	Same as topical, taken as a pill	PRELIMINARY	Off-label, prescription only, requires medical follow-up. MEDICAL ADVICE
Ketoconazole shampoo	Anti-inflammatory, may have mild anti-androgen effect on scalp	PRELIMINARY	Often used as an add-on. Safe and cheap.
Microneedling	Micro-injuries may boost growth with minoxidil	PRELIMINARY	Small studies. Do it under dermatologist guidance: infection and scarring risks if done wrong.
Low-level laser devices	Light therapy caps or combs	PRELIMINARY	Some FDA-cleared devices, modest effects, expensive.
Rosemary oil	Unclear	PRELIMINARY	One small trial compared it to 2% minoxidil. Not enough to replace proven options.
Hair transplant	Moves follicles from the back of the head	MEDICAL ADVICE	Surgery. Only with a board-certified surgeon, usually once loss has stabilized.

THE THINGS TO AVOID

Buying finasteride or other drugs online without a prescription: unknown doses, counterfeit products, no medical follow-up. WARNING

Biotin and "hair growth" supplements: no evidence they help unless you're truly deficient, which is rare. High-dose biotin can also distort some blood test results, the FDA has warned. WARNING

Shampoos and serums promising to "regrow" hair with no proven active ingredient. WARNING

6.6 Myths, quickly

Myth	Reality
Wearing hats causes baldness	No. Only very tight headwear worn constantly could cause traction.
Shaving makes hair grow back thicker	No. The cut end feels blunter, but thickness and growth don't change.
Cutting your hair makes it grow faster	No. Growth happens at the root.
Hair loss comes from your mother's side	Genes from both parents play a role.
Stress makes you go bald	Severe stress can trigger temporary shedding (telogen effluvium). It doesn't cause pattern baldness on its own.

6.7 If you're thinning: styling options

- **Go shorter.** Short sides and a textured top hide thinning better than longer hair that separates.
- **Matte products**: shiny products show the scalp. Clay or matte paste, applied to dry hair.
- **Buzz cut + beard**: a confident, clean look many men wear well. Balancing a shaved head with some beard adds structure to the face.
- **Avoid the comb-over.** It draws attention to exactly what it tries to hide.

6.8 Your module 06 checklist

- ☐ I've adjusted my washing frequency to my scalp and hair type.
- ☐ If I have dandruff, I've started a medicated shampoo 2–3 times a week.
- ☐ I've taken top and hairline photos (front, temples, crown) as a baseline.
- ☐ I've compared with photos from 1–2 years ago.
- ☐ If I see signs of loss, I've booked a doctor's appointment instead of buying products online.

Sources

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This module is for aesthetic and educational purposes only. It does not replace advice from a qualified healthcare professional.